ACT / SCIENCE / FREE GUIDE

ACT Science Strategy Guide

A clear approach to tables, experiments, and competing scientific explanations.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Confirm your test format

Science is optional for ACT National testing; school-day availability can depend on the state or district contract. Check your registration and any institution requirements. If you are taking Science, this guide focuses on interpreting evidence rather than memorizing a long list of facts.

Read the axes and units

Before interpreting a figure, identify what each axis measures, its units, and whether its scale is evenly spaced. In a table, trace the correct row and column. A rising line can mean many things; the labels tell you which quantity is changing.

Understand the experiment

The independent variable is what the researchers vary. The dependent variable is what they measure. Controlled conditions are held constant. Ask whether the design supports a causal conclusion or only an observed association.

Compare viewpoints precisely

For competing explanations, write a short mental summary of what each scientist claims. Separate agreement from disagreement. When asked which result would support one view, connect the proposed result to that view’s specific prediction.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

Light per day	Plant A height after 14 days	Plant B height after 14 days
2 hours	5 cm	4 cm
4 hours	8 cm	7 cm
6 hours	11 cm	9 cm

Original worked example

Using the table, how much taller is Plant A at 6 hours of light than at 2 hours?

11 − 5 = 6 cm. Use the Plant A column for both values. The table alone does not show how tall either plant will be after 28 days.

A tip worth keeping

“According to the data” means use the displayed evidence. Do not replace it with what you think normally happens.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. At 4 hours of light, what is the height difference between Plant A and Plant B?

2. Which listed light level gives Plant B its greatest measured height?

3. Does the table prove that 8 hours of light will produce a 13 cm Plant B?

Answers & explanations

1. 1 cm: $8 - 7 = 1$.

2. 6 hours per day, where the recorded height is 9 cm.

3. No. That is outside the displayed data and assumes a trend that has not been tested.

Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

Official ACT format updates

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